

ANI

done this. The previous LDF government also brought out yearly progress reports and implemented 100-day programmes. The latter are a means to further reinvigorate the entire government mechanism so that development activities and welfare measures are delivered to the people in a time-bound manner. We are upholding our commitment to the people by bringing out annual progress reports so that they themselves can decide whether we have delivered on our promises.

Q. How do you explain the dichotomy that Kerala is the most literate state but also the place where unemployment is higher than the national average?

A. Since 2016, we have issued advice memos to more than 200,000 youngsters through the Kerala Public Service Commission (KPSC). We have enabled the setting up of around 4,000 start-ups since 2016, which have created 40,000 employment opportunities. In the same period, the Kerala State Industrial Development Corporation (KSIDC) and Kerala Industrial Development Infrastructure Corporation (KINFRA) have created 49,594 employment opportunities. Our scheme for Non-resident Keralite Affairs (NORKA) has helped secure quality jobs for our youngsters in foreign countries. Through our Year of Enterprises scheme, we have created around 300,000 job opportunities; 1,153 interns have been appointed in local self-government institutes across the state. We have set up 30 cooperatives for youngsters, which have also generated job opportunities. Another 54,000 have been created in the IT parks since 2016.

Q. What are the immediate priorities of your government?

A. Our priority is to rebuild Kerala as a knowledge economy. To ensure that, we are strengthening the higher education sector. Enabling our young people to secure jobs in a knowledge economy is a big part of this. So we are focusing on skill development, industrial reorganisation and agricultural innovation. Our education and health facilities are going to be world-class. Farmers' incomes have increased by at least 50 per cent. Absolute poverty is being eradicated through family-based microplans. We are presenting an alternative to the policies of privatisation and liberalisation pursued by successive Union governments, by protecting the public sector and improving government services, while staying accountable to the people. Over the next few decades, Kerala's standard of living will rise to that of middle-income developed nations. We are creating a new Kerala, one that guarantees economic growth and does not compromise on social welfare.

> ***OF LATE, THE UNION IS SIDELINING FEDERAL PRINCIPLES AND ATTEMPTING TO CENTRALISE ALL POWERS... THROTTLING THE STATES***

Q. Do you think the south needs a platform of its own if the BJP at the Centre is ignoring its demands?

A. It is not a question of south versus north. It is essentially a matter of federalism, including fiscal federalism. States have elected governments that should discharge their constitutional duties. The Union too has constitutional duties to discharge towards the states. But, of late, the Union is sidelining federal principles and attempting to centralise all powers. They even go to the extent of assuming and exercising powers they do not have. In that sense, the Union government is throttling the states, particularly the opposition-ruled ones. Even the BJP-ruled states are feeling the brunt of the Union's overreach.

Q. You have a good rapport with chief ministers in the south, all of whom belong to anti-BJP parties. Do you that is the reason for the BJP targeting you?

A. It isn't me personally who is being targeted. It is the government of Kerala that is being targeted. Why? Because we are opposed to the policies and politics of the BJP-RSS combine and are championing a people's alternative. It is the people of Kerala who are being targeted. They are being denied their fair share of the country's resources. Why? Because they defeated the lone sitting MLA of the BJP in the Kerala legislative assembly, because they did not elect even a single BJP candidate as an MP from the state.

Q. Despite being a national party, the Congress has failed to act as an effective Opposition. Where do you think its failures lie—a crisis of leadership or a soft approach towards the BJP and its agenda?

A. They do not have an ideology that is opposed to the BJP. The BJP is implementing the same neo-liberal policies that the Congress had earlier spearheaded, albeit with renewed vigour. I do not need to go into instances from history to detail how anti-federal, authoritarian and communal Congress governments have been. The BJP has been able to overturn the people's verdict in several state assemblies due to the non-committal attitude of the Congress. So, the people of India themselves do not see the Congress as a party that can challenge the BJP. ■